measures endowed moral meaning to what had, till then, been auspicious days in the calendar of kingship and ritual.

Did these measures lead to a change in the food habits of the emperor's subjects? There is no doubt that Ashoka's intent was taken seriously by his officers and governors. An epigraph at Deotek near Nagpur in Maharashtra, which recorded the command of a lord ('Sami') prohibiting the capture and slaughter of animals, is indicative, punishments being specified for those who dared disobey his command.[42] Even so, there is no way of ascertaining the impact of Ashoka's vegetarian predilection. In an archaeological calendar, processes that can be detected exist as relatively large chunks of time. Thus, within the layers of excavated cities and villages of his time, it becomes impossible to specify the archaeological levels that constitute the reign of Ashoka. If coins had been minted that bore the portrait of the king or had there been other kinds of artefacts emblematic of his time, a reasonably precise archaeological chronology for this Mauryan emperor would have been reached. So, on the question of whether the king's orders modified meat consumption, all one can do is to look for clues indicating a reduction in the early historic period (which includes but is not limited to the time of Ashoka).

Since the pillar edicts are overwhelmingly in North India, we could look at the fauna at sites excavated there. At several such, bones show the range of meat that was consumed and offer a broad picture. At some sites large quantities of bones have appeared: at Raja Nala-ka-Tila in the Sonabhadra area of Uttar Pradesh, there were nearly 1600 fragments of animal bones in Period III (the early historic North Black Polished Ware phase), suggesting there was no reduction in meat-eating over this time.[43] The overwhelming preference here was for cattle and buffalo meat, followed by that of the sheep and the goat. Wild animals and birds were eaten, including wild cattle ('gaur' and buffalo), deer, wild pigs, cranes, and peafowl. The early historic phase (North Black Polished Ware phase) at Siswania in the Basti district of